mobile phone and Aadhaar number can now avoid navigating cumbersome bureaucratic hurdles. The state government has introduced an online portal to streamline the registration of marriage, divorce and inheritance. For those in remote areas and villages, Common Service Centre agents and Gram Panchayat Development Officers have been tasked with bringing these services to their doorsteps. Additionally, the introduction of Tatkal Seva offers fast-track registration for a nominal fee.

While the government touts these measures as progressive, criticism has proceeded on several fronts. One relates to whether the state's infrastructure can handle the scale. The mandatory registration of live-in relationships has drawn particular ire. Couples must register within a month of cohabitation, with non-compliance leading to penalties, including fines or imprisonment. This requirement has been labelled by many as an intrusion into personal lives. "If I continue to live in Uttarakhand, I will have to register under the UCC. They cannot enter our bedrooms," a 33-year-old businesswoman in a live-in relationship in Dehradun told INDIA TODAY. She is considering leaving the state. Many live-in couples share her concerns, perceiving the provision as moral policing under the guise of legal reform. In response, Uttarakhand's home secretary Shailesh Bagauli emphasised the law's role in safeguarding women's rights while assuring that their privacy would not be violated. "Sometimes untoward incidents happen in such relationships. This law will ensure the safety of women," he said.

Amid the controversy, there also emerged stories of citizens embracing the change and finding its digitised processes positive. Dhami himself was the first to register his marriage on the new portal, followed by ordinary citizens like Nikita Negi Rawat, 42, and Anjali Verma, 26. For Rawat, a state I-T official, the streamlined process was a revelation. "The normal process involves a lot of hassle. With this portal, I got my marriage registered quite easily," she said. Verma, who opted for the Tatkal service, echoed similar sentiments, calling it a "game-changer".

For the BJP, Uttarakhand's UCC is both a calculated risk and a strategic experiment. The state's religious and cultural identity adds symbolic weight to the law, positioning it as a test case for the party's national ambitions. In fact, the day the new law was rolled out, Vice President Jagdeep Dhankhar predicted it will set the stage for nationwide adoption. Haryana chief minister Nayab Singh Saini joined the chorus, expressing his intent to introduce it in his state "at an appropriate time". That also showcased how the law's internal contradictions can create a quagmire. Already, Uttarakhand's Scheduled Tribes are excluded from its ambit—the idea of tribals being allowed to preserve their cultural autonomy is likely to be extended nationally. Essentially, therefore, even in its first iteration, the uniform code is not exactly uniform. In Haryana, on January 17, representatives of a dozen khap panchayats had met Saini and urged him to ban live-in relationships and even same-gotra marriages. Will there then be two UCCs that are also not uniform across states? Back in Uttarakhand, Muslim bodies have vowed to move the courts against the infringement on their personal law. All this presages a complex journey ahead for the UCC. ■

KEY PROVISIONS OF UCC



X/@pushkardhami

▲ CM Pushkar Singh Dhami announces the UCC rollout, Jan. 27

↘ Marriage
Mandatory registration within six months; ban on polygamy and child marriage (minimum marriageable age of 18 for women and 21 for men)

↘ Divorce
Uniform divorce grounds across communities; practices such as triple talaq, iddat and halala criminalised

↘ Live-in relationships
Mandates registration to provide legal recognition, thus ensuring rights of partners and children. But penal provisions raise questions over the right to privacy

↘ Inheritance
Equal property rights for sons and daughters; children born out of live-in relationships, surrogacy and adoption are treated as legitimate heirs

↘ Applicability
It applies not only to state residents but also its natives living elsewhere

↘ Exemption
Scheduled Tribes are exempted, allowing them to continue following their customs